# Smt. Radhika Nandakumar : Bharatanatyam

**Radhika** was inspired, initiated into dance by her mother *Kalakovide* Guru *Smt. Usha Padmanabhiah* (foremost disciple of *Natyacharya* Guru *V.S.Koushik*, Founder of *Sanatana Kalakshetra*). **Radhika's** creative resources were carefully nurtured, intensively disciplined, and trained in Bharatanatyam by her mother. She performed *Rangapravesha* at the age of ten. **Radhika** received further training from Gurus *Sri U.S.Krishna Rao* and *Smt.Chandrabhaga Devi* in Pandanallur style and in Mysore school.

A gifted danseuse with distinct individuality, **Radhika** has developed numerous innovative forms of dance expressions from contemporary life. Her art focuses in setting-up a dynamic equilibrium between textual traditions and *Gurukula* traditions in dancing. **Radhika** has added a new dimension to contemporary Bharatanatyam by borrowing from the past, for the present and future. Her restorations are authentic, meaningful, and colourful.

She has choreographed the original, authentic restorations of *Jakkini, Shuddha Kavitha, Kaivara Prabandha, Sarthaka Mishra Kaivada, Suladi Nritya* etc to present them in a very aesthetic mood. She has made a comparative study of the *Abhinaya* of *Jayadeva*'s *Ashtapadi*s in both the authentic Tanjore Style and the Mysore Style of Bharatanatyam. **Radhika** has choreographed some of the most outstanding dance features like *Narada Koravanji* of Sri Vadiraja Yateendra (perhaps the very first *Koravanji* ballet in south India), *Navagraha Nrutya* (based on the concept of the nine planets), *Srunganatya* (based on the descriptions by *Nandikeshwara* in *Bharatarnava* and one of the most innovative fusion of Bharatanatya and Yakshagana of Karnataka), *Kumara Sambhavam* (of *Kalidasa*), *Soubhagya Lalita* (based on the theme as in *Lalitopakhyana* and *Srividya*), *Manmatha Vijaya* based on *Soundarya Lahari* (of *Sri Adi Shankaracharya*), *Mrigasandesha* (based on the *Panchatantra* and *Hitopadesha*), *Deshabhava Dundubhi* (choreography of a rare Ballard on the independence movement in India), *Pandarika Natya* (based on the textual descriptions as in *Nartana Nirnaya* of *Pandarika Vitthala*), etc. Radhika has experimented with new dimensional Chorographical Roopakas like *Urvashi* (based on Kumara Bharata), *Rangapushpa* (a roopaka based on varieties of Pushpanjali and Dikpalastuti), *Lakshmi Swayamvara Samavakara* : of Venkamatya, (one of the Dasha roopakas), *Ambe* (contemporary portrayal of the Ambe character in Mahabharata Epic), *Panchali Shapatha* (based on the portrayal of Draupadi of Vyasa Bharata), *Shivarudraksha* (based on Sri Jayachamaraja Wodeyar's compositions and theme taken from Shivatattva Sudhanidhi),

*Jaya Saudamini* (based on Sri Jayachamaraja Wodeyar's compositions), *Bhima Bhamini* of Vadiraja Yateendra (based on Deergha Kriti choreographies), Choreographies to *Tulasidas's Ramacharita Manasa, Sharana Sati Nijaguna* and *Nijaguna Bharata* (based on Sri Nijaguna Shivayogi's Kaivalya Paddhati), Pramatha Gatha (Gatha style of narration and based on various Ganesha Puranas. It contains many unique themes that are hitherto unexposed on contemporary dance field), *Virupaksha Vasantotsava* (based on the Champu Kavya of Ahobala of Vijaynagara, Hampi) and *Indradhvaja Mahotsava* based on Natyashastra and Vishnu Dharmottara Purana.

**Radhika** has now reconstructed the **'Gaundali Dance Form of Karnataka'.** She received a Fellowship from the Ministry of Culture, Government of India to pursue this work and she has dedicated much of her art life these days to bring this Art form in all its authenticity to our contemporary Art Stage. This endeavour would bring into a new light, the Nartanadhyaya of Sarngadeva's Sangita Ratnakara (Bharata Nartana) into the world of dance. Such performances have ensured for her a niche in the academic and performing world of Indian dance.

**Radhika** has a wide repertoire of well known and little known conventional Bharatanatyam compositions. She has uniformly attracted rave notices from distinguished dance critics, scholars, and connoisseurs of art.

**Radhika**'s marriage to the renowned musician Nandakumar opened a new chapter in her dance life. The Golden Lotus acquired the fragrance of Mysore Mallika. For, the hearts of this artist couple throb together in resonance and consonance, in creative inspiration and feedback. Their performances are vibrantly alive and replete with *bhava* and *rasa*.

Endowed with a tall graceful bodyline, sustained by vigorous Yoga and dedicated dance practice, with confident and exquisite Rasabhinaya, **Radhika** has a commendable stage presence, which motivates her to accomplish effective and elevating dance expressions. **Radhika** is the founder of Brahmavidya ®, a Foundation for Indian Arts through which she endeavours to realize and achieve the true doctrines of Indian culture.

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